

BEFORE

Growth in trade across the Sahara led to the formation of more centralized states south of the Sahara desert, such as the Ghana Empire.

MUSLIM TRADERS

Islam spread across North Africa from Arabia in the 7th century CE. 174–77. The introduction of camels to Africa by Muslim Arabs made travel possible through the desert, enabling Arabs and North African Berbers to open the first regular trade routes between North Africa and regions south of the Sahara desert. Muslim traders created trading networks throughout the sub-Saharan regions of East and West Africa.



TRADERS WITH CAMELS CROSS THE DESERT

THE EMPIRE OF GHANA

In the 8th to 11th centuries, the Ghana Empire of West Africa grew powerful on the trans-Saharan gold trade. Its rulers became Muslim in the 11th century, but then it declined in influence and was supplanted in the 13th century by the Mali Empire.

“... stones of marvelous size... with no mortar joining them...”

VICENTE PEGADO, CAPTAIN OF THE PORTUGUESE GARRISON AT SOFALA, 1531



Freestanding masonry

The wall of the Great Enclosure has a marble core, and is bounded on each side by horizontal, free-standing masonry. The wall contains 900,000 large granite blocks, and is decorated with a chevron pattern along the top.

South of the Sahara

Buoyed by trading links with Asia and Islamic North Africa, a number of prosperous empires and commercial centers formed in Africa to the south of the Sahara desert, including the Mali and Songhay empires in West Africa and Great Zimbabwe in south-central Africa.

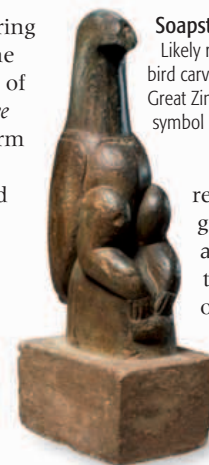
The cosmopolitan trading towns along the Swahili east coast of Africa were the first to benefit from the commercial activity, their coastal position helping them to monopolize the maritime trade with India, Persia, and Arabia. By the 13th century, Muslim trading cities such as Kilwa, in present-day Tanzania, were at the center of a highly profitable mercantile network, importing textiles, spices, and ceramics from Asia and exchanging these for African gold, iron, ivory, and slaves.

Great Zimbabwe

The Swahili ports did not produce these goods themselves, but traded in turn with states from within the African interior. At one end of the supply chain lay the settlement of Great Zimbabwe, an important source of gold, and the hub of a prosperous trading empire that

thrived in southern Africa during the 11th–15th centuries. In the language of the Shona people of the region, the word *Zimbabwe* meant “houses of stone,” a term applied to the hundreds of stone-walled enclosures found throughout the Zimbabwe plateau. Great Zimbabwe is the largest of these, located on the southern edge of the plateau. The spectacular stone ruins today cover nearly 1,800 acres (7 km²) and are divided into hilltop and valley complexes.

Built at the head of the Sabi River valley, Great Zimbabwe was well placed to control the passage between the gold fields in the west and the trading cities along the Swahili coast. Local natural resources supported the



Soapstone bird

Likely representing the bateleur eagle, these bird carvings stood on walls and monoliths in Great Zimbabwe, and have become the national symbol of Zimbabwe.

region’s economy: seasonal grazing was available for cattle and the soil was fertile enough to support the core cereal crops of sorghum and millet. Lumber and ivory were in plentiful supply. In the 12th–13th centuries, Great Zimbabwe also profited from taxes on the trading caravans that passed through the area.

City of stone

In the 13th–14th centuries, the people living in and around Great Zimbabwe probably numbered between 11,000 and 18,000, and most would have lived in huts, situated closely together. The ruling elite led a more privileged and comfortable existence, supported by the wealth provided by their control over the export of gold and ivory to the coast. Local granite was used to enclose the hilltop at Great Zimbabwe with stone walls, perhaps as a fortification.

The Great Enclosure

The outer wall of the Great Enclosure at Great Zimbabwe is 820 ft (250 m) in circumference, and as high as 80 ft (25 m). An inner wall runs along the outer wall, and forms a narrow passage that leads to the conical tower.



The Hill Complex

The buildings above the Great Enclosure may have been built as fortifications, although the walls offer no access to the top from which to repel attackers. Another theory is that it was created to show the power of the ruler.

Conical tower

The mysterious conical tower at Great Zimbabwe is 33 ft (10 m) high and 16 ft (5 m) in diameter. Its purpose is unknown, although it has been suggested that it was a symbolic grain bin.